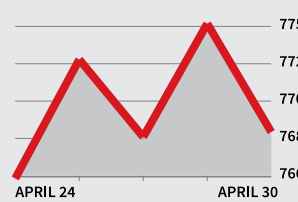


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76913.50 (-582.86)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23997.55	-180.10
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.94	-0.16
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.91	+0.06
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149661.00	+2281
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	240331.00	+4031

DUTY RELIEF.

Textile Ministry proposes temporary cut of import duties on cotton to ease input costs for apparel exporters **p10**



SMART SUPERVISION.

Banking is built on judgment and not just models, says RBI Deputy Governor Swaminathan **p8**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

LAND BORDER NATIONS
Final nod yet to come for liberalised FDI rules



New Delhi: The decision to liberalise FDI norms for countries sharing a land border (LBCs) with India, including China, is awaiting a final green light as the Finance Ministry is yet to notify the formal changes under the FEMA law. While the Cabinet has cleared the DPIIT proposal to ease beneficial ownership rules, consultations are still on at the Department of Economic Affairs with the final FEMA notification expected soon. **p3**

ON UNEVEN NOTE
Indian IT firms see patchy demand in Q4

Bengaluru: IT services firms closed Q4 on an uneven note, with growth increasingly concentrated in AI-led, non-discretionary segments such as BFSI, energy and life sciences, even as manufacturing, telecom and retail lagged under macro and tariff pressures. **p9**

India moves to secure energy fleet with ₹51,000-crore vessel acquisition plan

WAKE-UP CALL. Reducing external dependence to create a self-reliant logistics ecosystem is key objective

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Amid disruptions linked to the West Asia conflict, India is moving to secure its energy shipping fleet, placing maritime capacity at the centre of economic resilience.

State-run oil and shipping companies are lining up a largescale vessel acquisition programme, floating tenders for manufacturing 28 vessels, including LPG tankers and medium range (MR) crude oil carriers, in FY27.

ENERGY SUPPLY CHAINS With geopolitical tensions repeatedly exposing the fragility of global energy supply chains, the government is accelerating efforts to plug a long-standing vulnerability on account of India's reliance on foreign-flagged vessels to transport crude oil, liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), liquefied natural gas (LNG) and refined products. In this backdrop, the FY27 programme is part of a



TIME TO LEAD. The government is accelerating efforts to plug a long-standing vulnerability on account of India's reliance on foreign-flagged vessels to transport crude oil, LPG and LNG

broader fleet expansion plan, under which India aims to invite bids for 62 vessels in the current financial year ending March 2027, adding roughly 2.85 million gross tonnage (GT) capacity at an estimated investment of ₹51,383 crore.

The push also reflects gaps in domestic fleet availability across segments, such as container ships, green tugs,

LPG carriers, crude tankers and dredging vessels. Mukesh Mangal, Additional Secretary, Shipping Ministry, said the government has an aggregate demand for 437 vessels by FY42.

Of this, the target is to invite bids for 62 vessels in FY27, with tenders already floated for 34 vessels so far. Last year, the government had come out with a ₹70,000

crore package to develop India's shipping ecosystem.

"Our effort is that these orders should go to domestic players; for example, if somebody has to buy a VLGC or a VLCC... So, right now, these vessels are not being manufactured in India. If these orders should not go to foreign companies, then we should have some kind of manufacturing facility within India. So, we are developing ship manufacturing within our country and we have a target of floating tenders for 61-62 vessels within this year. Out of that, around 30-34 vessels tenders have been floated," he added.

SELF-SUFFICIENCY

The broader objective, officials said, is to reduce external dependence, strengthen supply assurance during global disruptions, and anchor a self-reliant marine logistics ecosystem that can support India's growing energy and trade requirements.

To address this, the Ministries of Shipping and Oil

have operationalised a joint venture (JV) between the Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) and oil and gas PSUs to drive bulk procurement. Under the plan, the SCI-led JV will float tenders for 34 vessels, while the ONGC will separately invite bids for 25 vessels, together accounting for around 2.8 million GT and an investment of ₹47,800 crore over the longer term till FY42.

TENDERS FLOATED

As part of the one-year acquisition roadmap, ONGC has initiated global tenders for 12 platform support vessels and anchor handling tug boats, with a right of first refusal for domestic players.

Bids for four vessels have already been floated. Parallely, the SCI-PSU JV is moving ahead with tenders for 14 vessels, including very large gas carriers (VLGCs) and MR tankers, with 10 tenders already issued.

The SCI, as part of its independent business plan, has also floated tenders for two MR tankers.

Federal Bank to acquire select credit card portfolio from Standard Chartered

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Federal Bank will acquire a select credit card portfolio of 4.5 lakh cards from the Standard Chartered (India) Bank. The two entities have agreed to sign an agreement to this effect.

The transaction values the portfolio at 1.5-1.6 times the implied equity as estimated by Federal Bank. The final consideration will be linked to actual balances at the time of transfer, Federal Bank said in a statement.

Federal Bank has an existing base of 8 lakh non-co-branded cards and 13 lakh co-branded cards. Its non-co-branded credit cards receivables will increase by an anticipated 90 per cent.

The final portfolio, including the number of cards acquired, will depend on the timing of the final transfer and customer consent.

The transaction, upon completion, will expand Federal Bank's credit card base and significantly deepen its presence in tier-1 cities with a high-quality customer base, per the statement. "Geographically, the ac-



quisition is a major strategic gain for Federal Bank, with approximately 75 per cent of the acquired card base concentrated in India's top eight cities, leading to Federal Bank's presence more than doubling in these locations," said the bank.

According to Reuters, Standard Chartered has about 6.4 lakh credit cards in India as of March-end, and it is selling that portfolio where customers hold only credit cards without a banking relationship.

KVS Manian, MD and CEO of Federal Bank, said: "This acquisition represents a compelling and strategic addition to our retail credit franchise. The portfolio we are acquiring is of good quality, highly seasoned active credit card users, and is concentrated in the markets that align with our strategy. This further accelerates the growth of our already fast-growing cards business."

+ Rupee down to 94.91/\$ on rising oil prices, FPI outflows; RBI intervention slows fall

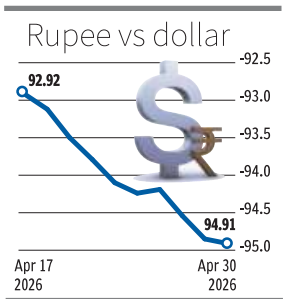
Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee on Thursday closed at a record low of 94.91 against the US dollar, breaching the psychologically crucial 95 mark intra-day for the first time since March 30. Surging crude oil prices, persistent foreign portfolio investor (FPI) outflows and importer demand weighed on the currency.

However, the RBI's aggressive intervention ensured that the currency closed below the 95 level, helping it to recover most of its losses. The rupee ended down about 6 paise *vis-a-vis* the previous close of 94.85.

CRUDE OIL SPIKES

The rupee depreciated sharply during the course of



the day as global crude oil prices spiked to a four-year high.

Crude oil prices are being driven by continued disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz in the wake of the West Asia war. They also reacted to US President Donald Trump's remarks that the blockade would not be lifted until Iran abandoned its nuclear programme. Brent crude briefly surged to around \$126 per

barrel before easing. During the day, the rupee fell to an all-time low of 95.3325, breaching the previous intra-day low of 95.22 on March 30.

Forex traders said the rupee came under pressure on multiple fronts — hardening crude oil prices, FPIs selling to the tune of \$201 million in Indian equities and heightened fears of further depreciation prompting importers, especially oil marketing companies, to ramp up dollar purchases. These factors pushed the demand for the greenback.

CASCADING EFFECT

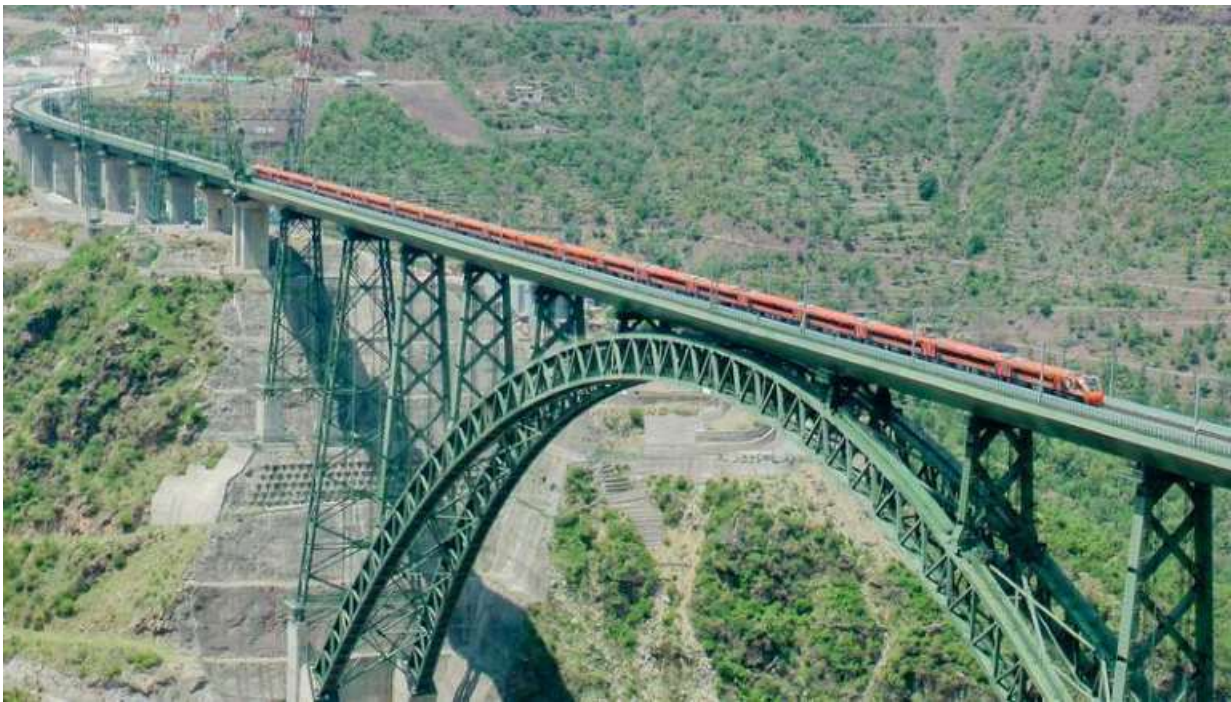
According to Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, what the forex market is witnessing is a textbook reflexive trade,

with rising oil prices triggering FPI outflows, FPI outflows compounding the dollar demand from oil importers, and the combination overwhelming the RBI's defensive measures.

He noted that April alone had seen FPI outflows of \$7.5 billion, taking calendar year-to-date exits past \$20 billion, compounded by a higher oil import bill as Brent rose from \$72 in February to \$118 today.

"The two channels — trade deficit and capital account — are pulling in the same direction and the rupee has no natural buffer. The RBI will continue to intervene, but its strategy is volatility management, not level defence. Reserves are being deployed to slow the move, not reverse it," said Banerjee.

GATEWAY TO VALLEY



ANOTHER MILESTONE. A Vande Bharat Express crosses the Chenab Bridge in Jammu and Kashmir's Reasi district. Railways Minister Ashwini Vaishnav flagged off the 20-coach train between Jammu and Srinagar on Thursday, with services for the general public to commence from May 2. The new service, which is the first in history, is expected to boost tourism and provide all-weather surface transport to the Valley **(Report on Page 12)** **p71**

India Inc in the hunt for global deals

Companies looking at international assets to expand market access and enhance capabilities

Rohan Das
Chennai

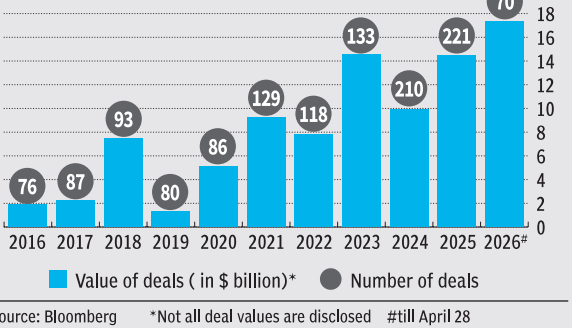
Sun Pharma's recent mega acquisition of US-based Organon has put the spotlight on India Inc increasingly pursuing global buys to gain market access and enhance capabilities.

There have been more than 70 acquisitions of international companies by Indian-owned businesses in the first four months of 2026, with the total value about \$17.3 billion, according to Bloomberg data sourced by *businessline*.

For some deals, the value remains undisclosed and, hence, the total spend could be higher.

Major deals in 2026 (besides Sun Pharma's Organon buy) include IKS Health's \$533 million acquisition of TruBridge, In-

Going global



fosys' \$465 million buy of Optimum Healthcare, and Wipro's \$375 million takeover of Mindbridge. The deal activity was also up in 2024 and 2025, and has been gradually rising after a period of slowdown between 2016 and 2020, when annual outbound acquisitions were in the range of 70-90.

As for the sectors, tech companies, especially tier-1 IT services firms, led the overseas buys, while industries such as pharmaceuticals, healthcare and renewable energy are also seeing increasing interest.

Speaking to *businessline*, analysts said that in recent years, Indian companies, equipped with better bal-

Major deals in 2026 include IKS Health's \$533 m acquisition of TruBridge and Infosys' \$465 m buy of Optimum Healthcare

ance-sheets, are looking at international assets to expand market access and for capabilities that would take them years of research and development effort.

"Indian market is one of the most expensive in the world and with the same scale, you get much better deals overseas as the valuations are not that high," said Sen Abhijit, Partner-Transaction Diligence at

Deloitte. Since most acquisitions are of US assets, they also help generate dollar revenues, which acts as a good hedge against the depreciating rupee, he said.

Abhijit also noted that especially in IT, acquisitions help bypass the long gestation of building capabilities such as artificial intelligence internally when established players are bought.

ACCESS TO FINANCE

Sumeet Abrol, Partner and Deals Lifecycle Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat, said better access to financing is also playing a role. "A lot of the mid-market companies have been getting creative with financing and other structures such as leveraged buyouts, which were earlier bastions of only large corporations," he said.

At ₹16,207 cr, HUL Q4 revenue grows fastest in twelve quarters

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) reported March quarter results broadly in line with street expectations, with revenue rising 8 per cent year-on-year at ₹16,207 crore, its fastest growth in 12 quarters, with clear improvement in underlying performance.

STEADY RECOVERY

The company showed a steady recovery through the year, with growth improving after weaker trends earlier in FY26. For the full year, revenue grew 5 per cent to ₹63,763 crore, as earlier quarters were weaker despite a strong finish.

MD and CEO Priya Nair said the company's focus on portfolio, brand investment and distribution led to a "progressive step-up in per-

formance" through the year.

Margins, however, remained under pressure. EBITDA margin stood at 23.7 per cent, down 50 basis points year-on-year, as input cost inflation, partly linked to crude and West Asia disruptions, continued to weigh. EBITDA growth lagged revenue expansion, reflecting higher brand investments, weak full-year EBITDA expansion and limited operating leverage.

ONE-TIME GAIN

The Q4 net profit rose 21 per cent to ₹2,992 crore, aided by a one-time gain from stake sale, while underlying profit grew 4 per cent in the quarter and remained flat for the full year. Excluding the one-time gain, the net profit was a little over ₹2,700 crore.

Growth was broad-based, led by home-care and beauty and wellbeing. Home-care grew 9 per cent, driven by

strong performance in fabric wash and liquids, reinforcing its role as the company's volume engine. Beauty and wellbeing rose 8 per cent, supported by premium portfolios and hair-care, though mass skin-care remained subdued.

Foods and personal care grew 5 per cent each. Foods was led by coffee and nutrition brands, such as Horlicks and Boost, while tea saw muted value growth due to price deflation. Personal care growth was driven by skin cleansing, while oral care remained soft.

Niranjan Gupta, Executive Director, Finance, and CFO, said cost inflation remains elevated at 8-10 per cent, while price increases have been limited to 2-5 per cent, reflecting a calibrated approach. The company has not seen supply disruptions despite geopolitical volatility, he added.

The real turnout

Record polling percentages reflect lower voter base

The 2026 Assembly elections have delivered striking headlines: West Bengal registering an unprecedented 92.47 per cent turnout and Tamil Nadu following with 85.10 per cent. Assam and Puducherry, too, have recorded their highest-ever participation. On the face of it, this suggests a decisive deepening of democratic engagement. But a closer look at the numbers, especially after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, shows that these record percentages rest on a significantly altered base.

West Bengal illustrates this most sharply. The numbers suggest that the headline turnout of 92.47 per cent in 2026 is at least partly a function of a sharply reduced electorate. The voter roll, at 6.81 crore, is lower by about 77.4 lakh (a contraction of 10.2 per cent) compared to the 2024 Lok Sabha election, and by roughly 53.1 lakh (7.2 per cent) from the 2021 Assembly polls. Yet, in absolute terms, the number of votes polled in 2026, about 6.30 crore, is only modestly higher than the roughly 6.05 crore votes cast in both 2024 and 2021, an increase of just about 4 per cent. This indicates that while participation has indeed risen, the dramatic spike in turnout percentage is amplified by a smaller denominator. The Tamil Nadu numbers tell a more nuanced story behind the headline turnout of 85.10 per cent. The electorate has contracted sharply, to 5,67,74,436, down by about 55.6 lakh (8.9 per cent) from 2024 and 61.7 lakh (9.8 per cent) from the 2021 Assembly polls. Yet, in absolute terms, the number of voters has actually risen: 4,83,13,946 ballots were cast in 2026, compared to 4,35,60,393 in 2024 and 4,64,06,392 in 2021. This means participation has increased by nearly 10.9 per cent over 2024 and by about 4.1 per cent over 2021. The surge in turnout, therefore, is real but not as dramatic as the percentage suggests.

Kerala presents a milder version of this pattern. The electorate has declined from 2,77,49,159 to 2,71,06,059, a drop of about 6,43,100 voters, or roughly 2.3 per cent, even as turnout reached 78.13 per cent, among the highest in its history. Assam, by contrast, has seen its electorate expand from 2,33,75,087 in 2021 to about 2,50,21,408 in 2026, an increase of roughly 6.8 per cent, while still recording a peak turnout of 85.38 per cent. In cleaning up the electoral rolls, the SIR has reset, or shrunk, the denominator against which participation is measured, Assam being the lone exception. The percentage rise, therefore, seems large even if the absolute increase in votes is modest.

None of this detracts from the administrative achievement or the visible enthusiasm of voters. The danger lies in reading a statistical outcome as a political signal. That said, the exclusion of *bona fide* electors seems to have occurred everywhere, largely because of the hurry in which SIR was conducted. These unfortunate errors should be rectified. The SIR should be ideally be seen as an exercise that enhances the credibility of the electoral process.

POCKET: The Summer of ‘26

RAVIKANTH



New credit loss norm could hurt

PLAYING SAFE. The ECL rules risk exclusion of capable, asset-light borrowers — favouring weaker borrowers with collateral



For decades Indian banks managed bad loans under the Incurred Loss (IL) approach. Banks provisioned only after borrowers actually defaulted. The Reserve Bank of India is changing the Asset Classification, Provisioning, and Income Recognition norms. From April 1, 2027, banks must shift to the Expected Credit Loss (ECL) framework, from backward-looking IL model.

The RBI is asking lenders to anticipate crashes before they happen. Loans will be classified into three stages based on extent of credit deterioration. Stage 1 category (performing assets, no significant increase in credit risk) requires provisions for expected losses over the next 12 months. Stage 2 (performing assets with significant increase in credit risk but not credit impaired) and Stage 3 (non-performing or credit impaired) categories require lifetime loss coverage.

ECL uses three variables: Exposure at Default (EAD), Loss Given Default (LGD), and Probability of Default (PD). Together, they estimate not just current stress, but future vulnerability. This new rule retains the existing norms for classifying non-performing assets (i.e., 90-days overdue), complemented by the banks' assessment of any forward looking credit risk requiring additional provision. For example, Stage 1 identification or the shift from Stage 1 to Stage 2 can occur irrespective of the current 90-day overdue norm. Therefore, credit risk could be triggered by 30+ days past due (rebuttable), rating downgrades, borrower stress, or portfolio-level signals.

Prudent ECL creates a policy dilemma: does systemic resilience come at the cost of credit rationing? As of March 2025, Indian banks held net advances of ₹15,905,063 crore, of which, around 75 per cent are secured by collateral or guarantees, leaving 25 per cent unsecured (*see Table*). On paper, this appears comfortable. In reality, collateral values often collapse during systemic stress due to fire-sale effects, where assets cannot be liquidated near book value. This weakens recovery rates



Banks' lending profile

Year	Advance	Tangible assets	Guarantees	Unsecured	Unsecured %
2013	58,79,773	45,62,786	3,96,411	9,20,577	15.7
2014	67,35,213	53,44,050	3,55,240	10,35,871	15.4
2015	73,88,160	58,32,621	3,99,440	11,56,100	15.6
2016	78,96,467	61,82,189	3,77,339	13,36,939	16.9
2017	81,16,109	63,35,567	3,94,114	13,86,428	17.1
2018	87,45,997	67,11,787	3,40,641	16,93,570	19.4
2019	96,76,183	73,06,226	3,25,281	20,44,676	21.1
2020	1,03,01,897	76,53,630	3,22,771	23,25,496	22.6
2021	1,08,06,381	79,82,866	3,83,556	24,39,959	22.6
2022	1,21,98,769	86,54,421	4,90,938	30,53,411	25.0
2023	1,43,19,353	1,00,71,488	5,89,855	36,58,009	25.5
2024	1,71,42,340	1,20,98,909	7,00,126	43,43,305	25.3
2025	1,59,05,063	1,11,28,866	7,48,608	40,27,589	25.3

Source: RBI, Statistical Tables Related to Banks in India

and raises Loss Given Default (LGD).

Once banks lose confidence in collateral recovery, they tighten lending, not because borrowers are weaker, but because security becomes unreliable. Unsecured advances rose from 15.7 per cent in 2013 to 25.3 per cent in 2025, lowering recovery rates and thereby increasing ECL provisioning pressure. Now the question remains: will this potential increase in provisioning trigger credit rationing?

When banks demand collateral to reduce unsecured exposure, borrower behaviour creates a natural

Raising interest rates worsens borrower quality, so banks manage risk by restricting access to credit rather than increasing prices — this is credit rationing

self-selection. Safe borrowers, confident of repayment, are willing to pledge assets, while riskier borrowers avoid collateral because they expect a higher chance of default. Under ECL, this sorting becomes sharper. Since banks must account for LGD from day one, unsecured loans carry a much higher immediate provisioning burden. As a result, banks may simply avoid offering unsecured credit altogether.

In credit markets, when demand exceeds supply, interest increase fails to clear the market, due to the Stiglitz-Weiss Theory. Under this, if a bank tries to "price in the risk" of an unsecured loan by charging a 20 per cent interest rate, the "safe" borrowers who have low-margin, low-risk projects leave the market because the cost eats their entire profits. "Risky" borrowers remain because they only plan to pay if their high-stakes project succeeds. The bank knows that it is left with a Akerlof's "lemon" pool of borrowers. To avoid this, the bank keeps interest rates lower

Why India cannot afford to ignore tech sovereignty

If control over critical digital assets vests in another country, access to essential data could be restricted suddenly

Rajesh Nambiar

Over the past two decades, India has made extraordinary strides in bringing technology into the centre of national life. By almost every measure of digital adoption, India has done something remarkable. Yet much of the technology infrastructure that powers this transformation is not owned by India. Most businesses run on foreign platforms. Critical systems including government services, hospitals, banks, power grids, and supply chains flow through foreign clouds or rely on systems ultimately controlled outside our borders.

The question this raises is simple. What happens if that access is suddenly restricted?

In 2025, the chief prosecutor of the International Criminal Court reportedly lost access to his email after a technology provider complied with government instructions. Around the same time, an Indian company, Nyara Energy, suddenly lost access to essential cloud tools. These were not cyber criminals breaking into systems. These were administrative decisions made by legitimate service providers.

For a nation as large and ambitious as India, being a mere consumer of technology is a risk we can no longer afford to take.

However, when we talk about technology sovereignty, it is easy to get lost in the clouds. Sovereignty, in this context, means the ability to make

consequential decisions about ones own digital infrastructure without being subject to another country's veto. Broadly, it relates to control over critical digital assets along with the associated physical and intangible enablers such as human expertise and the governing regulatory framework.

It is equally important to understand what this is not. Technology sovereignty does not mean we stop using foreign innovations or that we try to build every single tiny component ourselves. Instead of viewing it as techno-isolation, it must be seen as having the intellectual property, the local talent, domestic capabilities and the legal authority to ensure our most critical systems like power grids, financial networks, and defence systems are resilient.

LESSON FROM ABROAD

India is not alone in facing this problem. Other countries have been grappling with the same questions, and their approaches offer us a useful map, even if none of them fits India's situation perfectly.

The first approach is full ownership. China built its own versions of almost everything, its own search engines, social media platforms, payment systems, and increasingly its own chips and cloud infrastructure, supported by substantial state funding and strict limits on foreign players.

The US arrived at a similar outcome through an entirely different route. By producing private companies that the entire world came to rely on. The second



GLOBAL APPROACHES. India must incorporate them for tech sovereignty

approach is regulatory power. The European Union does not own global technology, but it shapes how global technology behaves within its borders and, increasingly, beyond. European data protection rules, competition regulations, and standards for artificial intelligence have become reference points that even American companies must follow to access European markets.

The third is strength through partnership. The Chip 4 arrangement between the US, Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan around semiconductor supply chains is one example. As on date, India lacks foundational IP in most advanced technologies, has limited critical minerals and semiconductor capacity and, importantly, our bargaining power *vis-à-vis* jurisdictions of global big tech parent companies is weak.

Further, while our talent base is huge, depth in deep-tech areas is limited;

building such expertise will take years.

India will need elements of all three global approaches to technology sovereignty.

Rather than choosing one model, India should adopt a layered strategy where different parts of the technology stack are addressed differently and the approach evolves over time. The most practical path combines domestic capability building, smart regulation, trusted global partnerships, and market driven innovation.

The most important structural step India can take is to establish a National Technology Sovereignty Council, a permanent, functioning institution tasked with synergising disparate efforts and developing a technology sovereignty framework which defines short- and medium-term priorities, approach for each technology layer, and tracks progress against defined metrics.

Alongside this, the government must engage industry as a genuine partner rather than simply as a regulated sector. Policymakers must evangelise the business case for sovereignty aligned investments beyond compliance, facilitate technology transfer from global majors, and catalyse collaborative R&D in sovereignty aligned areas through industry consortia and shared labs. Technology sovereignty is not a project for the long term. The decisions made in the next three to five years will determine what options India has in the decade after that.

The writer is President, Nasscom

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Tech vs ethics

Apropos 'Challenge of Mythos' (April 30). The new AI model Claude Mythos shows how technology can now find and exploit weaknesses in computer systems faster than humans. This power can help protect networks but also create new risks if misused. Governments and companies must act quickly to set fair rules and share responsibility. Cybersecurity is no longer just about fixing problems — it is about managing power wisely. Mythos reminds us that progress must come with caution, because the same

intelligence that builds safety can also break it if left unchecked.

K Chidanand Kumar
Bengaluru

Ethanol transition path

This refers to 'Centre pushes for 100% ethanol-powered vehicles' (April 29). Building on E20's success, the move towards E100 signals a clear step towards energy independence. However, higher ethanol blends reduce fuel efficiency and may raise running costs. Feedstock expansion must be managed without straining land and

food needs. This calls for closer alignment between policy ambition and field readiness. A phased rollout, supported by stable supply chains and transparent pricing, can ease the transition.

S Balasubramanian
Villupuram, TN

Millet consumption

Apropos 'Millets are still not on our menu' (April 30), it is really disheartening to learn that consumption of millets, which are rich in iron, calcium, fibre and so on, is falling despite India accounting for

nearly 38 per cent of global output of the commodity. Once people develop a habit of consuming millets (like how they have for rice, wheat, etc), then it will become permanent item on their menu.

S Ramakrishnasayee
Chennai

Deciphering rupee's fall

This refers to 'Why the rupee has fallen steeply' (April 30). The authors make a persuasive case that the rupee's sharp fall was driven less by weak fundamentals and more by sentiment-driven capital flows. The

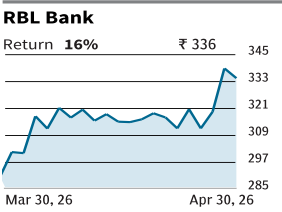
self-fulfilling nature of depreciation expectations is a genuine concern, and the RBI's intervention appears justified on those grounds. That said, the deeper structural issue deserves attention: India's relative shortage of AI-related stocks and slower corporate earnings growth made it a less attractive destination when global capital grew cautious.

Addressing that gap is a medium-term imperative that monetary intervention alone cannot substitute for.

M Barathi
Bengaluru

QUICKLY.

Shift in control at RBL Bank gets SEBI nod



Mumbai: SEBI has approved a change of control at RBL Bank, the lender said on Thursday, related to a proposed deal that would see Dubai's Emirates NBD acquire a majority stake. The nod from SEBI marks a key regulatory milestone for one of the largest cross-border deals in the country's financial sector. A change of control in a listed company involves a shift in the right to appoint directors and manage policies and requires prior SEBI approval. REUTERS

Hindustan Lab, RK Steel get SEBI nod to float IPOs

New Delhi: Generic drug maker Hindustan Laboratories and steel tubes and pipes manufacturer RK Steel Manufacturing Company have secured SEBI's approval to raise funds through initial public offerings, an update with the markets regulator showed on Thursday. Hindustan Laboratories' IPO comprises a fresh issue of 50 lakh shares, along with an OFS of 91 lakh shares by the promoter, according to its DRHP. The company proposes to utilise IPO proceeds for funding working capital requirements and general corporate purposes. RK Steel's IPO is entirely a fresh issue of up to 2 crore shares, draft papers showed. PTI

Corrigendum
With respect to "Broker's Call" (April 30, 2026), the target price for IndiGo (InterGlobe Aviation) should read as ₹5,300 and not as published. The error is regretted.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

MANKIND PHARMA (BUY)
Target: ₹2,640
CMP: ₹2,246.55
Mankind Pharma's domestic formulation (DF) business is witnessing a healthy revival, with March 2026 growth at 11.5 per cent year-on-year vs IPM growth at 10.6 per cent, driven by chronic therapies (cardiac up about 20 per cent/anti-diabetic up about 12.6 per cent), indicating improving execution and field force stability after restructuring. Growth drivers are strengthening structurally, with the performance of new Rx launches surging 4.8x over the past three years (to ₹520 crore in MAT March 2026) and a concentrated contribution from top brands (about 65 per cent). Moreover, a rapidly scaling up in-licenced/partnered portfolio (about 3x growth, led by respiratory) is building a dual-engine growth model for Mankind. BSV has moved past the integration phase, with a strong pick-up in growth in Q3FY26, driven by normalisation in operations and improved execution. With cost synergies having largely been realised, the next phase will be led by revenue synergies, cross-selling opportunities and operating leverage. Overall, we expect a CAGR of 13 per cent/11 per cent in DF/export revenue over FY26-28, led by restructuring-led revival and strengthening revenue synergy in acquired products. Accordingly, we expect 16 per cent EBITDA CAGR over FY26-28. This would be further supported by a declining interest outgo, driving 27 per cent earnings CAGR over FY26-28. We value Mankind at 35x 12M forward earnings to arrive at a TP of ₹2,640. Reiterate Buy.

JP Morgan

MEESHO (OVERWEIGHT)
Target: ₹215
CMP: ₹193.05
Meesho is building India's first discovery-led marketplace that acts as a long tail ad network with embedded logistics for a fragmented retail market. We believe the Q2-Q3 drop in logistics monetisation was a one-off as a result of 3PL consolidation and should recover in FY27. While we are sceptical of annual transacting user growth being constrained in the late teens, we think Net Merchandise Value (NMV) can be sustained at a 23 per cent FY26-31 CAGR. In addition, Mall & Content Commerce (about 5 per cent of NMV each), at a 50 per cent FY26-31 CAGR, brings down the burden of growth on the core platform to just a 16 per cent CAGR, which appears reasonable. Meesho has been successful in monetising tier-3 and below markets that are complementary to mainstream e-commerce and quick commerce company target groups. With a broadening of SKU mix to Home & Kitchen and BPC from fashion, it has the option of expanding its target group to include customers from metro/tier-1 and premium segments through its Mall initiative. Further, we see EBITDA margins expanding to 4 per cent by FY31, thanks to under-monetised ad take-rates. This should drive EBITDA/FCF CAGR of 170 per cent/52 per cent over FY28-31 post break-even. We value it at FY30 EV/EBITDA of 35x, discounting back to FY28 at ₹215 price target.

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Sensex, Nifty end 7% higher in April

RESILIENT RECOVERY. Indices surge sharply across-the-board despite weak ₹, surging oil prices, FPI pull-out

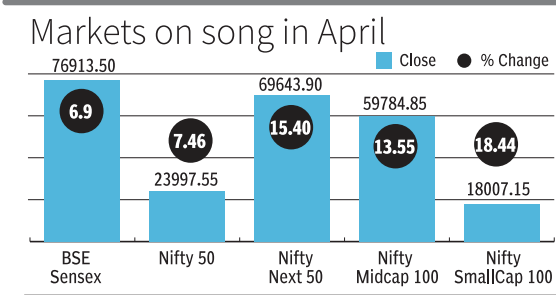
Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai
April, the first month of FY27, saw a sharp recovery across the board for Indian equities, despite benchmark indices down nearly 0.75 per cent on Thursday.

The Nifty and the Sensex surged around 7 per cent while Nifty Defence, Nifty Realty and Nifty Capital Market indices were resilient by skyrocketing 21-25 per cent in April. The Nifty IT was under pressure due to weak results but even that index closed 1 per cent higher in April. FPIs pulled out over ₹60,000 crore worth shares in April and the rupee breached the 95-per-dollar mark for the first time, as prolonged Iran war continues to worry investors. Crude oil price also crossed \$110 a barrel, making import-dependent In-

dian economy more vulnerable.

DOWNGRADES
The gain was despite global financial advisories, such as HSBC, JPMorgan and Bernstein, downgrading Indian equities. However, PL Capital has pegged a target of 27,080 for the Nifty 50, driven by an expected 15 per cent earnings CAGR over FY26-FY28, even as global uncertainties and rising crude prices cloud the near-term outlook. The US Federal Reserve held interest rates steady but maintained a firm policy stance, supporting the US dollar and tightening financial conditions for emerging markets.

STRONG PERFORMERS
Broader indices outperformed the benchmarks in April. The Nifty SmallCap 100 spiked 18.5 per cent, Nifty Midcap 100 jumped



Sectoral shiners		
	Close	% chg
Nifty Defence	8973.45	24.38
Nifty Capital Mkts	5238.05	23.20
Nifty Realty	793.55	21.87
Nifty Energy	40771.9	16.99
Nifty Media	1456	15.39
Nifty Metal	12833.05	15.21
Nifty Chemicals	28480.5	14.21

13.5 per cent and Nifty Next50 gained 15.4 per cent. The stars of April were MTAR Technologies, which surged nearly 86 per cent, followed by HFCL (71 per cent), Websol Energy (71 per

	Close	% chg
Nifty Tourism	7332.7	12.50
Nifty FMCG	51072.1	12.15
Nifty Bank	54863.35	9.13
Nifty Auto	25917.6	9.04
Nifty Oil & Gas	11694.65	8.40
Nifty Pharma	23267.7	4.66
Nifty IT	29353.9	1.00

cent), Sterlite Tech (67 per cent) and Lloyds Enterprises (65 per cent). Among the prominent stocks that scored handsome gains included Ola Electric that jumped over 60 per cent,

Cohance Lifesciences (60 per cent) and 63 Moons Technologies (58 per cent). HCL Technologies, Mangalore Refinery, Infosys and United Breweries were among the top losers, falling between 5 per cent and 10.60 per cent. Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said, "Despite weak global cues, elevated crude prices and a depreciating INR, India's equity markets rebounded from recent lows as investors used the correction to add exposure, supported by better-than-expected earnings despite geopolitical uncertainty." The earnings momentum and domestic inflow of funds are likely to support falls in the market, but volatility might be witnessed on account of FII selling, higher crude prices and global uncertainties, cautioned Vikram Kasat, Head Advisory, PL Capital.

SEBI speeds up process for AIF to launch schemes

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Thursday introduced a fast-track mechanism for processing private placement memoranda (PPMs) filed by alternative investment funds (AIFs), allowing for quicker launch of schemes and faster capital deployment. As part of an ease-of-doing-business measure, the regulator said AIFs, excluding large value funds for accredited investors (LVFs), can proceed with the "launch of their new schemes and circulate the PPM to their investors for soliciting funds after 30 days of filing of ap-

plication with SEBI, unless otherwise advised." For first-time schemes, AIFs can launch either from the date of registration or after 30 days from filing, whichever is later, the circular said. **PROCESS SHIFT** This marks a shift from the earlier process where SEBI reviewed PPM disclosures and issued comments before funds could proceed, often leading to delays. The regulator said the change was necessitated due to the "time-consuming nature of the extant procedure" and the need to enable "efficient deployment of capital by AIFs". However, SEBI clarified

SEBI penalises Axis Trustee for flouting disclosure norms

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Capital markets regulator SEBI has levied a fine of ₹10 lakh on Axis Trustee Services Ltd for disclosure and governance lapses linked to Embassy Office Parks REIT. Embassy REIT is India's first publicly listed Real Estate Investment Trust (REIT). The case relates to an August 19, 2024, order by the National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA), which found Aravind Maiya, then CEO of Embassy Office Parks Management Services Pvt Ltd, guilty of professional misconduct, imposing a ₹50 lakh penalty and a 10-year debarment from audit functions. In an order passed on April 29, SEBI said the Axis Trustee Services was informed of the NFRA order on August 20, 2024, but the disclosure to unit holders

was made only after a delay of 53 days. The regulator observed that the information was material as it impacted the competence and integrity of the CEO and required prompt disclosure.

RESPONSIBILITY SEBI noted that while the primary responsibility of disclosures lies with the manager, the trustee has a parallel and proactive duty to ensure compliance and address delays urgently. Further, the regulator observed that the trustee failed to independently assess whether Maiya met the 'fit and proper person' criteria despite a direction by SEBI on August 20, 2024. Embassy Office Parks Management Services Pvt Ltd is the manager of Embassy Office Parks REIT, which was sponsored by Bengaluru-based realty firm Embassy Group and global investment firm Blackstone.

M&M: A THREE-DECADE SAGA

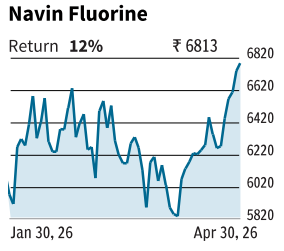


DRIVING FORCE. Anand Mahindra, Chairman, Mahindra Group, along with Ashishkumar Chauhan, MD & CEO of NSE, and others celebrating the 30th anniversary of Mahindra & Mahindra shares on the exchange

Navin Fluorine hits 52-week high on strong Q4 earnings

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Navin Fluorine International shares plunged about 6.5 per cent on Thursday, hitting a 52-week high, as strong quarterly earnings and upbeat growth visibility boosted investor sentiment. The stock rose to a high of ₹7,200 but closed flat at ₹6,821 on the NSE, compared to the previous close of ₹6,758.50. The company reported a 76.2 per cent y-o-y rise in standalone net profit at ₹135.03 crore for the quarter ended March 2026, up from ₹76.61 crore in the year-ago period. Revenue from operations grew 29 per cent y-o-y to ₹626.51 crore, supported by a strong performance across key segments. On a full-year basis, profit after tax more than doubled



to ₹487.67 crore in FY26 from ₹241.93 crore in the previous year. The board also recommended a final dividend of ₹8.60 per share.

MIXED VIEWS
Global brokerages remained divided on the stock despite the strong performance. Jefferies maintained a 'Buy' with a target price of ₹8,385, noting that EBITDA and profit after tax beat its estimates by 19 per cent and 30 per cent, respectively, driven by strength in specialty chemicals and CDMO segments. It

highlighted that multi-year contracts, capacity expansion in key products and a strong balance sheet position provide visibility for earnings growth over FY27-28, and expects a 24 per cent EPS CAGR over FY26-28. Citi maintained 'Sell' with a target price of ₹6,500, pointing out that while EBITDA rose 80 per cent y-o-y and margins remained strong at 34.2 per cent, there were potential downside risks to re-frigerant pricing amid capacity additions. DAM Capital retained 'Buy' with a target price of ₹7,769, highlighting broad-based strength with the sixth consecutive quarter of growth in revenue and profitability. Elara Capital reiterated 'Buy' with a revised target price of ₹8,681, citing improved earnings visibility and a transition into a multi-year compounding phase.

AVI Polymers' promoters plan to hike stake by 5%

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The promoter group of AVI Polymers plans to acquire up to 5 per cent of the company's total paid-up equity share capital through open market transactions. The company has received an official intimation from the promoters on the same, and it was conveyed to the board. The proposed acquisition underscores the promoters' confidence in the company's long-term growth strategy and intrinsic value. The planned stake increase follows AVI Polymers' performance in FY26. **REVENUE SURGE** The company reported a surge in revenue to ₹312 crore and a multi-fold growth in net profit, alongside achieving a debt-free

balance sheet and a strengthened net worth position. The promoters' move comes at a time when AVI Polymers is transitioning into a technology-driven enterprise, supported by the successful operational roll-out of wholly-owned AI-led subsidiaries, including KrishiBuddy and AVI Health AI. **PHASED ACQUISITION** The acquisition will be carried out in a phased manner over the coming months, in compliance with SEBI's applicable regulatory frameworks. Chintan Patel, Managing Director, AVI Polymers, said, "As we continue to build a technology-driven business with new-age platforms, such as KrishiBuddy and AVI Health AI, we believe the current valuation presents a compelling opportunity."

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 180.10 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Infosys	1181.80	10.93	16.26	3.76	
Bajaj Auto	9994.00	10.88	31.44	1.01	
Reliance Ind	1430.80	7.95	20.22	8.78	
Sun Pharma	1808.30	6.83	29.61	1.74	
Bajaj Finance	937.00	4.08	31.82	2.28	
Kotak Bank	383.30	2.09	20.28	2.56	
Tech Mahindra	1473.50	1.90	30.04	0.85	
Maruti Suzuki	13314.00	1.63	28.52	1.59	
Coal India	481.45	0.77	9.55	0.99	
SBI Life	1819.00	0.27	73.02	0.74	
Wipro	200.65	-0.02	15.86	0.52	
TCS	2473.90	-0.18	18.10	2.30	
HCL Tech	1199.10	-0.25	19.54	1.15	
Asian Paints	2444.50	-0.28	59.97	1.00	
Adani Ports	1657.30	-0.61	30.55	1.11	
Grasim Ind	2794.50	-0.72	20.08	0.97	
Bharti Airtel	1886.80	-0.87	31.03	5.26	
Dr Reddys Lab	1322.90	-0.92	19.99	0.73	
Cipla	1309.60	-0.98	23.34	0.67	
Adani Enter	2408.40	-1.09	22.02	0.63	
NestleIndia	1458.60	-1.09	80.38	0.95	
ONGC	299.55	-1.57	8.38	1.06	
Apollo Hosp	7635.50	-1.60	58.44	0.71	
HFCL Life	586.90	-1.76	66.22	0.57	
PowerGrid Corp	318.35	-1.98	19.07	1.31	
Bajaj Finserv	1747.20	-2.14	14.57	0.92	
Max Healthcare	993.05	-2.20	68.09	0.67	
NTPC	399.15	-2.22	15.59	1.77	
Eicher Motors	7109.00	-2.42	36.40	0.89	
Int'lGlobeVtr	4295.30	-2.46	51.72	2.88	
ITC	314.90	-2.84	19.06	2.76	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	246.37	-3.10	100.28	0.73	
JSW Steel	1264.50	-3.11	39.82	1.08	
TataConsumerProduct	1144.60	-3.32	76.97	0.68	
Trent Ltd.	4144.60	-4.05	85.59	0.84	
Bharat Elec	431.30	-4.84	52.14	1.64	
Adani	4385.20	-4.91	81.69	1.64	
Tata Motors PV	341.55	-5.09	46.45	0.65	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	937.35	-5.95	22.00	1.19	
UltraTech Cement	11586.00	-6.38	41.70	1.25	
Tata Steel	211.36	-6.15	28.93	1.59	
Windolco	104.21	-6.92	19.44	1.37	
M&M	3997.50	-10.68	22.79	2.55	
Eternal Ltd.	247.03	-10.99	65.135	1.63	
Hind Unilever	2250.90	-12.29	52.60	1.81	
State Bank	1068.45	-16.69	11.40	4.03	
Axis Bank	1268.30	-17.58	14.85	3.31	
L&T	4041.40	-21.02	29.10	4.28	
HDFC Bank	771.70	-24.94	14.99	3.02	
ICICI Bank	1263.40	-27.44	15.61	8.21	

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 877.90 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Adani Power	221.85	30.01	37.86	3.72	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1562.90	11.61	27.47	2.71	
Tata Capital	533.15	9.82	28.91	0.58	
Siemens	3808.20	7.83	85.54	1.36	
Britannia Ind	5726.00	5.65	57.08	2.73	
Solar Industries	15439.00	4.26	91.51	1.52	
Hyundai Motor India	1817.60	0.08	25.51	1.05	
AvenueSuper	4585.90	-3.12	104.19	2.74	
Bajaj Holdings	10267.00	-4.11	12.75	1.80	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	1041.21	-4.94	19.44	1.10	
Abn India	7230.00	-5.71	90.85	0.85	
Jindal Steel	1223.10	-5.23	61.89	1.84	
HindustanAeronautics	4338.80	-6.86	32.62	3.34	
Union Bank	165.94	-7.47	6.32	1.30	
Siemens Energy India	3278.80	-7.79	98.84	1.18	
Maazagon Dock	2733.20	-7.83	45.81	0.84	
Cummins India	5366.40	-8.24	65.12	2.88	
Bosch	35995.00	-8.57	38.51	1.27	
MuthootFin	3424.20	-11.17	15.89	1.49	
Divis Lab	6502.50	-11.30	69.63	3.35	
Pidilittind	1375.70	-11.64	60.51	1.73	
MacroTech Developers	897.90	-11.76	26.14	1.02	
ZydusLifesciences	891.90	-13.38	17.86	0.90	
Shree	367.00	-13.49	32.81	1.53	
Df	24195.00	-13.59	48.60	1.31	
Torrent Pharma	4185.10	-13.70	62.34	1.77	
Ltimindtree	4269.60	-14.01	25.41	1.61	
AdaniGreenenergy	1227.15	-16.70	101.73	1.67	
Punjab Natl Bank	109.36	-17.72	7.03	1.53	
Ambuja Cements	4474.30	-23.90	22.31	1.10	
Gil (India)	163.23	-18.50	12.47	1.78	
Bpcl	300.45	-19.74	5.30	2.47	
Indian Oilcorp	142.25	-20.46	5.45	2.15	
Hindus Zinc	595.95	-20.93	18.20	1.05	
Indian Hotels Co.	633.85	-21.81	41.82	2.26	
Canara Bank	134.65	-22.94	6.63	1.54	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	815.35	-23.73	115.46	2.26	
Bank Of Baroda	263.46	-25.09	6.94	1.98	
SamvardmotherSonInternatl	121.21	-25.36	35.15	2.17	
Godrej Consumer	1067.10	-26.06	59.94	1.74	
United Spirits	1325.60	-31.52	56.06	1.59	
Rural Elec	388.30	-32.61	5.72	1.79	
Tata Power	444.55	-32.84	28.36	3.02	
Varun Beverages	513.70	-36.32	54.13	2.85	
Tvs Motor Cmp	3492.90	-40.44	54.34	3.32	
Tata Motors Cv	409.90	-41.59	91.66	3.47	
Hdfc Amc	2712.60	-43.31	40.66	2.24	
Power Finance	448.40	-47.21	4.43	2.65	
Adani Energy Solutions	1342.25	-74.21	67.28	1.69	
Vedanta	271.55	-2408.16	6.41	1.87	



Performance Highlights Q4 & FY26

All-time high consolidated total income and profit for the year



Consolidated Results (₹ In Crore)						
Particulars	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25	% Change	FY26	FY25	% Change
Total income	38,508	36,434	6%	1,50,530	1,32,944	13%
Profit before tax	6,928	6,002	15%	26,883	23,748	13%
Profit after tax (attributable to owners of the Company)						
- After the accelerated ECL provision, one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	2,539	2,417	5%	9,801	8,872	10%
- Before the accelerated ECL provision, one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	2,539	2,417	5%	10,508	8,872	18%



Consolidated Results (₹ In Crore)						
Particulars	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25	% Change	FY26	FY25	% Change
Total income	21,607	18,306	18%	81,990	68,847	19%
Profit after tax (attributable to owners of the Company)						
- After the accelerated ECL provision, one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	5,464	4,480	22%	19,017	16,638	14%
- Before the accelerated ECL provision, one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	5,464	4,480	22%	20,267	16,638	22%
Net NPA	0.41%	0.44%		0.41%	0.44%	
Return on average equity (annualised)	19.7%	19.1%		18.1%	19.2%	
Assets under management	5,09,975	4,16,661	22%	5,09,975	4,16,661	22%



Standalone Results (₹ In Crore)						
Particulars	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25	% Change	FY26	FY25	% Change
Total income	2,903	2,505	16%	11,151	9,554	17%
Profit after tax	669	587	14%	2,560	2,163	18%
Assets under management	1,40,706	1,14,684	23%	1,40,706	1,14,684	23%



Standalone Results (₹ In Crore)						
Particulars	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25	% Change	FY26	FY25	% Change
Gross written premium	4,322	4,326		23,326	21,583	8%
Profit after tax						
- After the one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	365	363		1,942	1,832	6%
- Before the one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	365	363		1,973	1,832	8%
Combined ratio	113.6%	104.8%		102.8%	102.3%	
Return on average equity (annualised)	11.3%	12.3%		15.9%	16.0%	
Assets under management	35,529	33,122	7%	35,529	33,122	7%



Standalone Results (₹ In Crore)						
Particulars	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25	% Change	FY26	FY25	% Change
Gross written premium	11,198	9,237	21%	32,896	27,160	21%
New business premium	4,757	3,789	26%	14,586	12,293	19%
Net value of new business	709	549	29%	1,626	1,152	41%
Shareholders' profit after tax						
- After the one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	73	41		226	508	
- Before the one-time charge of New Labour Codes and tax thereon	73	41		270	508	
Assets under management	1,33,563	1,23,734	8%	1,33,563	1,23,734	8%

Bajaj Finserv Limited | CIN: L65923PN2007PLC130075 | Website: www.aboutbajajfinserv.com/about-us
Bajaj Finance Limited | CIN: L65910MH1987PLC042961 | Website: www.bajajfinserv.in/finance
Registered Office: C/o Bajaj Auto Limited Complex, Mumbai - Pune Road, Akurdi, Pune - 411 035
Corporate Office: Bajaj Finserv Corporate Office, Off Pune - Ahmednagar Road , Viman Nagar, Pune - 411 014
Bajaj Housing Finance Limited | CIN: L65910PN2008PLC132228 | Website: www.bajajhousingfinance.in
Registered Office: Mumbai-Pune Road, Akurdi, Pune 411 035 | Corporate Office: B2, Cerebrum IT Park, Kumar City, Kalyani Nagar, Pune 411 014
Bajaj General Insurance Limited | (formerly known as Bajaj Allianz General Insurance Company Limited) | CIN: U66010PN2000PLC015329 and IRDA Registration No. 113 dated 2 May 2001 | Website : www.bajajgeneralinsurance.com
Bajaj Life Insurance Limited | (formerly known as Bajaj Allianz Life Insurance Company Limited) | CIN: U66010PN2001PLC015959 and IRDA Registration No. 116 dated 3 August 2001 | Website: www.bajajlifeinsurance.com
Registered and Corporate Office: Bajaj Insurance House, Airport Road, Yerwada, Pune - 411 006
Insurance is the subject matter of solicitation.

This is an abridged representation of the unaudited/audited financial results of Q4 and FY26 and is not for the purpose of legal compliance.
As required by regulations, the results for Bajaj Finserv, Bajaj Finance and Bajaj Housing Finance Limited have been prepared as per Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS).
The results of Bajaj General and Life Insurance Limited are as per Indian GAAP.



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Infosys plans Vizag centre with 7,000 seats



Hyderabad: IT major Infosys will set up a development centre in Visakhapatnam with a capacity of 7,000 seats. The Andhra Pradesh government has allotted 20 acres to the company to set up the centre. The company has scaled its workforce in Visakhapatnam from 250 employees in early 2024 to nearly 1,900 currently, with an additional 750 seats set to become operational soon. **OUR BUREAU**

Indo National to acquire Aidin Technologies

Chennai: Indo National, the company behind Nippo batteries, is entering the high-potential aerospace and defence sector. The board of directors of Indo-National, at its meeting held on Thursday, approved the proposed acquisition of 51 per cent of the paid-up share capital of Aidin Technologies, by way of subscription to compulsorily convertible preference shares for a total consideration of around ₹78 crore across two tranches. **OUR BUREAU**

Indian IT firms see patchy demand in Q4 driven by BFSI

DEMAND SHIFT. While North America remained broadly resilient, Europe is the next growth lever

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Indian IT services firms closed Q4 on an uneven note, with growth increasingly concentrated in AI-led, non-discretionary segments such as BFSI, energy and life sciences, even as manufacturing, telecom and retail lagged under macro and tariff pressures. While North America remained broadly resilient, Europe is emerging as the next growth lever on sovereign AI and regulatory-driven demand, marking a shift in regional momentum. Elara Capital noted a mixed Q4 for Indian IT majors, with growth concentrated in select verticals and regions. TCS saw North America-led growth, with BFSI, energy and tech holding up on AI-led modernisation, while communications and utilities lagged. Infosys was driven by Europe and North America, with BFSI and energy strong, but manufacturing, retail and communications under pressure from macro and tariff uncertainty. Wipro's growth was led by



UNEVEN GROWTH. Elara Capital noted a mixed Q4 for the IT majors, with growth concentrated in select verticals and regions

Europe and APMEA, though BFSI weakness in the Americas and cautious consumer and healthcare spending weighed. HCLTech saw traction in tech and BFSI, but declines in telecom, retail and manufacturing, with the US steady and Europe soft. Overall, the Americas remained resilient, Europe uneven and India/RoW stronger, while AI-led and non-discretionary spends continued to outperform broader discretionary demand. “BFSI has emerged as the clear frontrunner, with Persistent’s BFSI vertical growing 28.4 per cent in FY26 on a full-year basis at a \$600 million annualised run-rate, driven by top-four wins across the US and India

banks. Infosys’ Q4 call noted financial services and EURs grew above the company average. BFSI started AI-led modernisation 18-24 months ahead of other verticals, began data-readiness and cloud foundations earlier, and is now converting that into scope expansion, not just cost optimisation,” Sidhant Rastogi, President, Zinnov, said. Life sciences is another resilient pocket. During the company’s Q4 commentary, Infosys called out communications and life sciences as growing well above the company’s average. The weak pocket is manufacturing. The HCLTech CEO and MD said on the Q4 call that US telecom clients and SAP-related cancella-

tions drove specific Q4 weakness, and that JPMorgan expects telco weakness and SAP cancellations to persist into FY27. Tariff uncertainty is the underlying macro driver. Rastogi said clients in tariff-exposed sectors are deferring discretionary decisions until policy clarity emerges. “Tariff uncertainty in US manufacturing is showing up in specific client programme ramp-downs. The Daimler programme at Infosys is the highest-profile example. Manufacturing is now a 100-150 basis point drag on cohort growth that did not exist 18 months ago,” he said. **FINANCIAL SERVICES** Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst at Greyhound Research, explained that industries like financial services do not have the luxury of stepping back. “Technology here is tied to compliance, risk and day-to-day operations. Delaying investment is not an option. Healthcare and energy behave similarly. In each case, the systems being supported are critical and cannot be paused without consequence,” he noted. Public sector programmes also continue, especially where they are linked to long-term national priorities. These are usually less influenced by short-term shifts. There is little appetite for experimentation without control. Solutions that offer predictability, governance and reliability are preferred.

Eveready Industries posts 9.4% jump in revenue growth in March quarter

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Eveready Industries India reported a 9.4 per cent rise in consolidated revenue at ₹327.2 crore for the quarter ended March 31, 2026, compared to ₹299 crore in the same quarter last year, marking the sixth consecutive quarter of revenue growth. For FY26, consolidated revenue grew 8.2 per cent to ₹1,455.4 crore (₹1,344.5 crore). Profit after tax for Q4 FY26 stood at ₹141.8 crore (₹10.4 crore), though this includes an exceptional income of ₹102.7 crore from the transfer of leasehold rights for its Noida plant. For the full year, PAT came in at ₹1,71.5 crore (₹82.4 crore), with net exceptional gains of ₹48.6 crore embedded in the figure. Stripping out exceptional items, profit before exceptional items and tax for FY26 was ₹118.3 crore, up 20.1 per cent year on year.

Profit after tax includes an exceptional income of ₹102.7 crore from the transfer of leasehold rights for its Noida plant

The headline strategic development was the commissioning of a roughly ₹200 crore alkaline battery manufacturing facility at Bari Brahmna, Jammu — positioned as India’s only operational alkaline battery plant — inaugurated on April 22 by the Lieutenant Governor of Jammu and Kashmir. The facility has a peak capacity of 360 million units and is expected to reduce import dependence. Alkaline battery revenues surged 82 per cent in Q4 FY26, though the segment remains a small share of the overall battery mix at 12 per cent of revenue. Batteries remained the dominant business at 67 per cent of Q4 revenue, growing 8.6 per cent year-on-year. Lighting was the fastest-growing segment, up 17 per cent in Q4. Flashlights grew a modest 3.3 per cent.

Cognizant pre-leases 6.5 lakh sq ft in Chennai to set up global capability centre for US Bancorp

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

US-based Cognizant Technology Solutions has taken about 6.5 lakh sq ft of office space at Embassy Splendid TechZone in Chennai on pre-lease to set up a global capability centre (GCC) for US Bancorp, the American banking multinational. Sources in real estate said the deal is significant for Chennai’s GCC ecosystem, which recently saw Wells Fargo shifting operations to Bengaluru and Hyderabad.

Per multiple sources, Block 1 at Embassy Splendid TechZone, located on the Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam IT corridor, has been pre-leased by Cognizant; delivery is expected by June, as per an investor presentation by Embassy Office Parks REIT post its Q4 results.

LEASING DEAL For Embassy REIT, the Cognizant transaction was the largest leasing deal announced in the quarter, with Chennai emerging as a key contributor to its overall leasing activity.

Amit Shetty, CEO of Embassy REIT, said FY26 was an exceptional year for the company, with 6.4 million sq ft of leasing and double-digit growth across revenue, net operating income and distribution. Industry sources indicated that Cognizant will not only set up the GCC for US Bancorp, but also manage the operations. The centre is expected to follow a build-operate-transfer model, reflecting evolving approaches in the GCC space. In January 2025, Cognizant CEO S Ravi Kumar had

noted growing traction for GCCs in India, with the company securing over 10 such deals using varied models, including dedicated client facilities, in-house centres and BOT structures. The company even appointed Sailaja Josyula as Global Head of its GCC service line last year. Infosys and Wipro are also increasingly adopting flexible GCC models to serve global clients, underscoring the segment’s rapid evolution. US Bancorp and Cognizant did not respond to queries.

Amazon Now orders jump 25% month-on-month

Our Bureau
Bengaluru



Amazon CEO Andy Jassy

Amazon is seeing strong early traction in its quick commerce push, with orders on its Amazon Now service growing 25 per cent month-on-month, Chief Executive Officer Andy Jassy said during the company’s March quarter earnings call. The e-commerce major entered the ultra-fast delivery segment in June, later than rivals, but has since scaled the service across key metros, including Delhi NCR, Mumbai and Bengaluru, supported by around 300 micro-fulfilment centres.

able to tens of millions of customers across nine countries, with more to come as well,” Jassy said. The company is now stepping up expansion. On Monday, Amazon said it will take Amazon Now to 100 cities, backed by over 1,000 micro-fulfilment centres as it looks to deepen its presence across both metro and non-metro markets. **BROADER SURGE** The push comes amid a broader surge in India’s quick commerce segment, which is expected to grow into a \$40-50 billion market over the next few years, driven by rising demand for

convenience, faster deliveries and increasing urban consumption. Amazon’s expansion is part of its recently-announced ₹2,800 crore (\$300 million) investment to strengthen operations in India, aligned with its broader \$35 billion commitment by 2030. A portion of this will be used to double the footprint of its quick commerce vertical, including scaling store count and improving delivery speeds. Rival Flipkart has also been aggressively ramping up its presence, with nearly 100 dark stores being added every month.

Reliance Retail acquires Anomaly

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Reliance Retail announced on Thursday the acquisition of Anomaly, the haircare brand founded by actor and entrepreneur Priyanka Chopra Jonas, taking full ownership of the brand’s trademarks, digital assets and intellectual property. The deal expands Reliance Retail’s beauty portfolio and gives it control over a brand that has built distribution across several global markets. Financial terms of the acquisition were not disclosed. Anomaly, positioned as a clean, vegan and high-performance haircare range at accessible price points, will now be scaled through Reliance Retail’s network of over 20,000 stores and its digital commerce platform Tira. The company said India will be the priority market, with product innovation focused on Indian hair and scalp needs.

Edelweiss Financial Q4 profit falls 16%

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Edelweiss Financial Services reported a 16.65 per cent decline in its consolidated net profit to ₹132 crore for the March quarter. The company posted a net profit of ₹158.32 crore in the year-ago period. Its total income declined to ₹1,969.28 crore (₹2,343.26 crore), Edelweiss Financial Services said in a statement. Its board recommended a dividend of ₹1.5 per share. For FY26, the company’s net profit went up to ₹680.46 crore (₹536 crore).

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Telefax: 0712-2591661, CIN: L99999MH1962GOI012398

Extracts of audited financial results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026
(₹ in lakhs)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31.03.2026		Year ended 31.03.2026	
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited
1.	Total income from operations	44449.08	43339.02	147283.82	158494.09
2.	Net Profit/(loss) for the period (before tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	11435.24	12523.54	33784.01	48678.21
3.	Net Profit/(loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	11435.24	12523.54	33784.01	48678.21
4.	Net Profit/(loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	9261.30	11565.09	26747.97	38163.71
5.	Total comprehensive income for the period (comprising profit/(loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax)	6435.63	5253.24	21256.84	31851.56
6.	Equity share capital (Face value of ₹10 each)	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52
7.	Reserve (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Balance Sheet	250576.29	243441.32	250576.29	243441.32
8.	Earnings per share from continuing operations (Face value of ₹10 each)				
	Basic	4.55	5.68	13.14	18.76
	Diluted	4.55	5.68	13.14	18.76

Notes:
1. The above results, reviewed by the Audit Committee, have been approved by the Board of Directors in its meeting held on 29th April, 2026 and have been reviewed by Statutory Auditors of the company. This statement has been prepared in accordance with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 (Ind AS) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent applicable.
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. Financial results in detailed format are available on the websites of Stock Exchanges (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website (www.moil.nic.in).
3. MOIL has no subsidiary/associate/joint venture company as on 31st March, 2026.
4. Previous period's figures have been regrouped/classified, wherever necessary to make them comparable. The figures for the quarter ended 31st March, 2026/2025 are balancing figures between the audited figures of full year and reviewed figures upto 31st December, 2025/2024.

Scan QR Code for detailed Results

For MOIL Limited
Sd/-
Vishwanath Suresh
Chairman-cum-Managing Director
DIN : 10059734

Place: Nagpur
Date : 29th April, 2026

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EXTRACT OF THE DETAILED FORMAT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31 ST MARCH 2026						
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31 st March 2026	Quarter ended 31 st December 2025	Quarter ended 31 st March 2025	Year ended 31 st March 2026	Year ended 31 st March 2025
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	1,19,645	1,16,344	1,03,677	4,34,823	4,32,930
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period/ year before Tax	2,709	913	(24,084)	(22,840)	(69,297)
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period/ year after Tax	2,351	712	(18,319)	(16,640)	(52,139)
4	Total Comprehensive Income for the period/ year	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	Not Applicable
5	Paid-Up Equity Share Capital	51,566	51,557	51,543	51,566	51,543
6	Reserves (Excluding Revaluation Reserves)	-	-	-	1,26,438	1,42,958
7	Share Premium	78,028	77,982	77,908	78,028	77,908
8	Net Worth	1,78,004	1,75,599	1,94,501	1,78,004	1,94,501
9	Outstanding Debt	2,75,274	2,61,543	1,40,573	2,75,274	1,40,573
10	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	-	-	-	-	-
11	Debt Equity Ratio	0.98	0.46	0.56	0.98	0.56
12	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face Value of ₹ 10/- each)* - Basic (₹)	0.46	0.14	(3.56)	(3.23)	(10.13)
	- Diluted (₹)	0.45	0.14	(3.55)	(3.22)	(10.12)
13	Total Debts ** to Total Assets	8.92%	8.98%	5.17%	8.92%	5.17%
14	Capital Adequacy Ratio - Basel II	22.22%	22.68%	21.84%	22.22%	21.84%
15	% of Gross NPA to Gross Advances	5.41%	5.64%	6.87%	5.41%	6.87%
16	% of Net NPA to Net Advances	1.77%	2.73%	2.99%	1.77%	2.99%
17	Return on Assets *	0.08%	0.03%	(0.67)%	(0.60)%	(1.94)%

* Quarterly numbers are not annualised
**Debt represents borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year. Total debt represents total borrowings.

Note: 1) Capital Redemption Ratio, Debenture Redemption Reserve, Debt Service Coverage Ratio and Interest Service Coverage Ratio are not applicable, being a banking company.
2) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly financial results filed with the stock exchanges under Regulation 33 and Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Full Format of the standalone Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 is available on the Stock Exchange websites www.bseindia.com, www.nseindia.com and also on the Company's website www.esaf.bank.in.

Place : Mannuthy
Date : 30th April 2026

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Regd. & Corp. Office: ESAF Small Finance Bank, Building No. VII/83/8, ESAF Bhavan, Thrissur - Palakkad National Highway, Mannuthy, Thrissur, Kerala - 680 651.

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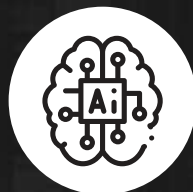
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QUICKLY.

US FDA proposes new curbs on weightloss drugs

The US Food and Drug Administration on Thursday proposed excluding active ingredients for Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly's weightloss drugs on the list of drugs outsourcing facilities can use for compounding. If finalised, the exclusion would limit compounding of these medicines unless they appear on the agency's drug shortage list. REUTERS

Trump floats new plan to reopen Strait of Hormuz

Washington: US President Donald Trump floated a new plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a senior official said. Under the plan, the United States would continue its blockade on Iranian ports, while coordinating with allies to impose higher costs on Iran's attempts to subvert the free flow of energy, according to a senior administration official. Trump is weighing multiple diplomatic and policy options to push Iran to end its chokehold on the waterway, said the official. PTI

Smartphone prices face year-long spike amid memory chip shortfall, say experts

PRICE ESCALATION. Component cost inflation impacting affordability and extending replacement cycles

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The Indian smartphone market is entering into one of its most challenging phases in recent years, with shipments projected to decline 10-13 per cent in calendar year (CY) 2026 — marking the steepest contraction since 2022, due to sustained component cost inflation, led by a sharp surge in memory prices, industry veterans have said.

The shortage is materially impacting affordability and extending replacement cycles, they said, adding that the price escalation is expected to continue for the next one year and hit low-end mobile phones the most.

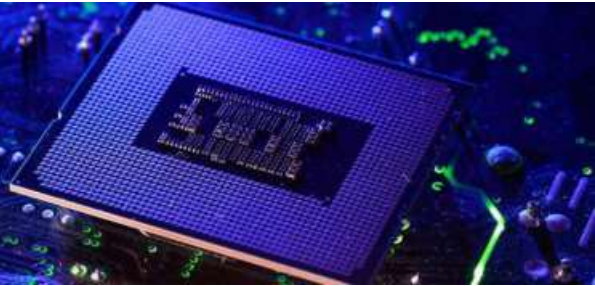
IMPORT DUTY

Experts said the government can also do nothing about it because import duty is already zero for such items and they cannot force any global company to supply more into the country.

“Driven by strong artificial intelligence (AI) demand and superior margins, memory manufacturers are increasingly allocating capacity toward high-bandwidth memory (HBM), tightening supply for conventional dynamic random access memory (DRAM) and NAND (memory chips that retain data without power)... We are already seeing this reflect in pricing trends — DRAM prices have firmed up sharply and are expected to remain elevated, while HBM continues to command a significant premium due to constrained supply,” Ashok Chandak, President, India Electronics and Semiconductor Association (IESA), told *businessline*.

CAPACITY TIGHTNESS

In the near term, capacity tightness is likely to persist through 2026, particularly in advanced nodes and packaging, with gradual easing expected only as new investments come online over the next two-three years, he said.



SUPPLY SQUEEZE. In the near term, capacity tightness is likely to persist through 2026

“As a result, the memory market is clearly bifurcating — HBM is seeing premium, AI-led demand, while conventional memory is becoming tighter and more expensive. This is beginning to impact entry-level consumer devices, where OEMs are recalibrating configurations and pricing. Importantly, this is leading to production optimisation rather than production cuts. OEMs and EMS players are actively adjusting product mix, sourcing strategies and cost structures, with no widespread reduction in manu-

facturing,” Chandak added. Similarly, Pankaj Mohindroo, Chairman, India Cellular & Electronics Association (ICEA), said that the global memory industry is undergoing a structural reconfiguration, with production capacity increasingly gravitating towards AI and data centre applications. “For the Indian mobile phone market, this is likely to weigh on near-term volumes, particularly in the entry and mid-tier segments, as the cost impact moves through the supply chain. That said, as supply dynam-

DoT cuts Vodafone Idea’s AGR dues to ₹64,000 cr

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Vodafone Idea (Vi) has received significant relief on its long-pending adjusted gross revenue (AGR) dues, with the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) cutting the payable amount to ₹64,046 crore as of December 31, 2025, from an earlier estimate of ₹87,695 crore following a reassessment.

The revised figure comes after a government-appointed committee reviewed the dues, in line with directions from the Supreme Court of India, which had earlier allowed the Centre to consider the company's grievances regarding AGR calculations.

LONG RUNWAY

The payment schedule provides a long runway for the debt-laden telco. Vodafone Idea will pay a minimum of ₹100 crore annually over four years between FY32 and FY35, with the remaining dues to be settled in six equal annual instalments from FY36 to FY41.

The AGR payment of ₹124 crore between March 2026 and March 2031 for FY2018

and FY2019 were not part of the reassessment. This means that Vi will pay ₹124 crore annually over the next six years from 2026 to 2031.

On December 31, 2025, the Cabinet had granted moratorium to the telco, freezing its dues at ₹87,695 crore and extending the payment schedule from FY32 to FY41. “In this regard, we now wish to submit that the DoT vide its communication dated April 30, 2026, has informed that the Committee formed for the purpose has finalised the AGR dues at ₹64,046 crore as on December 31, 2025,” said Vi in its exchange filing.

Shriram Subramanian, Founder of InGovern, said, “The payment terms seem lenient enough to grant bank loans for at least over the next four years. For banks, the uncertainty is in a sense addressed.”

Telecom expert Parag Kar said the telco's spectrum debt of ₹1.25 lakh crore poses a bigger challenge. “AGR is not an issue for Vi as regards their debt is concerned. They need to do a balance sheet repair. To do that they have to somehow reduce their spectrum debt.”

CCI overstepping judicial authority: Apple

Reuters
New Delhi

Apple has accused India's competition body of exceeding its powers by pushing the US tech company to submit its financials in an anti-trust case related to the iPhone apps market, while Apple challenges the law governing penalties, documents show.

An April 24 non-public Indian court submission by Apple is the latest sign of a growing confrontation between the company and

Indian investigators over a case in which Apple says it could face a penalty of up to \$38 billion.

The Competition Commission of India (CCI) has since 2024 sought Apple's financial information — typically needed to calculate penalties — after an investigation found it abused its dominant position.

ANTITRUST PENALTY

Apple has resisted, arguing it has challenged India's entire antitrust penalty calculation law in a New Delhi court, and

the watchdog must wait. After the CCI this month gave Apple an ultimatum to submit its financials and scheduled a final hearing on May 21, the company has urged the Delhi High Court to urgently intervene to put the matter on hold.

The “commission's decision to schedule a final hearing represents an escalation in its efforts to usurp the Court's authority,” Apple said in the filing, in which it asked the court to hear the matter on May 15.

The filing came in re-

sponse to CCI's April order, in which the watchdog said Apple had “been afforded adequate opportunities to file” its objections to the investigation report and has also “not submitted the requisite financial information”.

The Indian case is among many Apple faces around the globe for alleged antitrust breaches. India is a key market for Apple where its iPhones have a 9 per cent market share, compared to 4 per cent two years ago, according to Counterpoint Research.

Private airports call for increasing user fees

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Private airports have asked for an increase in user development fees from international passengers to compensate for the loss in revenue due to 25 per cent reduction in landing and parking charges of domestic flights ordered by Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA).

This is one of the suggestion proposed by the Association of Private Airport Op-

erators (APAO) to the Civil Aviation ministry.

TARIFF BURDEN

The APAO has said that airports are contractually obligated to remit revenue share/per passenger fee to the Airports Authority of India (AAI) as per the respective concession agreements.

In the absence of any corresponding interim relief on these outgoings, the burden of the tariff reduction disproportionately rests on the airport operators, it said.

“While the provision for

future true-up of under-recoveries in subsequent tariff periods is acknowledged, the immediate cash flow impact is significant. The mismatch between current revenue loss and future recovery places substantial strain on airport operations and debt servicing, particularly given the high fixed-cost nature of airport infrastructure,” the APAO said in a submission on Thursday.

The association suggested that revenue share/per passenger fee amount equal to reduction in landing and

parking charges could be deferred by AAI.

Similarly, the APAO has asked the government to direct AERA to immediately revise landing and parking charges after the relief period.

Earlier this month, the Civil Aviation Ministry introduced a slew of measures to support domestic airlines. Along with limiting price hike of jet fuel to 25 per cent, AERA also ordered 25 per cent reduction in landing and parking charges at major airports.

IHCL expands its premium homestay biz

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Indian Hotels Company Limited (IHCL) is expanding its premium homestay business with the signing of 10 bungalows in the Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

The bungalows are being developed by Terra Rex Realty on an investment of ₹100 crore (excluding land cost) and will be ready by next year.

“As travel preferences continue to evolve towards experience-led stays, the homestay segment has emerged as a strong driver of growth,” IHCL Managing Director and CEO Puneet Chhatwal said on Thursday after the signing.

IHCL's runs homestay business under the ama Stays & Trails brand. Currently, it has 185 homestays in operation and another 185 in pipeline. IHCL earns a management fee from operations, and it forms a part of its new business segment.

Direct Jammu and Kashmir rail service promises faster travel, economic growth

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday flagged off a 20-coach Vande Bharat Express from Jammu Tawi Railway Station, marking the launch of the first direct train between Jammu and Kashmir.

The service, the first in history, is expected to significantly reduce travel time and improve connectivity. The journey between Srinagar and Jammu will now take four-five hours, circumventing the steep and weather-prone road route.

CARGO MOVEMENT

Until now, there were no direct trains between Jammu and Kashmir. Passengers travelling from Srinagar had to disembark at Katra and board another train to reach Jammu.

Speaking to reporters, Vaishnaw said the railway link had already begun trans-



SEAMLESS TRANSPORT. Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw (centre), Union Minister Jitendra Singh (left), and Jammu and Kashmir CM Omar Abdullah flag off the Vande Bharat Express PTI

forming cargo movement in the region.

“Transportation of automobiles, cement, steel and other goods has become easier,” he said. He added that the network also benefited the movement of horticultural produce from the Kashmir Valley.

“About 2 crore kg of apples have been transported from the Valley to other parts of the country by railways,” he said.

Vaishnaw said efforts were

underway to enhance the capacity of the Jammu-Srinagar line, with projects such as automatic signalling systems and the construction of additional crossing stations in progress.

EXPANDING NETWORK

He said the government is focusing on expanding the network to Uri and connecting the districts of Poonch and Rajouri.

“The work will be carried out carefully to ensure that

apple orchards and natural beauty are not disturbed,” he said, adding that detailed project reports for these extensions were currently under preparation.

BUSINESS BOOST

“The direct trains will not only boost tourist footfalls but also strengthen trade, hospitality, handicrafts and the local transport sectors,” said Qazi Tauseef, spokesperson of the Kashmir Economic Alliance, an amalgam of traders, transporters and other business bodies in Kashmir.

He said seamless transportation would drive demand for hotels, restaurants, local products and services, benefiting thousands of livelihoods across the region.

“Additionally, enhanced rail connectivity integrates Kashmir more closely with the national economic framework, ensuring smoother movement of goods and people,” Tauseef added.

SpiceJet flight chaos hits flyers; three Mumbai flights cancelled

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Travel plans of hundreds of SpiceJet passengers went haywire due to inordinate delays and cancellations on Wednesday.

The airline said it was forced to cancel three flights from Mumbai to Bengaluru, Delhi and Gorakhpur due to operational reasons, while two others departed after long delays.

A SpiceJet spokesperson said three flights were cancelled from Mumbai due to operational reasons, including the grounding of an aircraft and network delays caused by adverse weather at Bagdogra.

WEATHER WOES

Two other flights from Mumbai to Ahmedabad were also impacted by weather conditions at Varanasi and Bagdogra.

This resulted in delayed aircraft arrival into Mumbai



POOR PERFORMANCE. The airline's overall punctuality was 43 per cent, the lowest among major airlines, and it had the most number of flights delayed by two hours or more

and led to subsequent delays.

Sources, however, pointed out that Thursday's disruption was not a solitary episode and for the past month, SpiceJet flights from Mumbai had faced delays.

According to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation's March statistics, SpiceJet's on-time performance at Mumbai was 29 per cent.

The airline's overall punctuality was 43 per cent, the lowest among major airlines, and it had the highest number of flights delayed by two hours or more.

A source said the airline had delayed payments to the

airport operator due to a cash crunch.

PASSENGER FURY

“Staff salaries have also been delayed and frontline staff face angry passengers on almost a daily basis,” a source said. SpiceJet said flights in Mumbai were not impacted by any payment-related issues, and there were no restrictions on departures.

On Wednesday, passengers vented their ire on social media and at counter staff as no explanation was offered for flight delays. Central Industrial Security Force personnel had to intervene to pacify agitated passengers.

Chocolate purchases online see big surge, driven by quick commerce

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Online penetration in the chocolate segment has grown by 65-70 per cent from about 9 per cent to about 13 per cent within a year fuelled by quick commerce, which is reshaping consumer purchase behaviour, according to a report by RedSeer Strategy Consultants.

It added that what was historically an occasion-led category is now increasingly anchored in high-frequency and impulse-driven consumption.

Nearly 20 per cent of chocolate orders on quick commerce platforms are placed post 9 pm, pointing to

the emergence of late-night purchase occasions with consumers making 1.3x higher spends per order strengthening the premiumisation trend, it added.

At the same time, a significant share of demand is concentrated in packs priced below ₹200, indicating a transition from bulk purchases to bite-sized, high-frequency indulgence.

IMPULSE CATEGORY

“Chocolate has always been an impulse category, but quick commerce removes the final friction, allowing purchases to happen instantly rather than as part of planned shopping. This is evident in the share of growth driven by the channel and in rising late-night

consumption,” said Kushal Bhatnagar, Associate Partner at RedSeer Strategy Consultants.

He added, “Brands need to have a unique playbook for quick commerce — product size, pricing, messaging — to accelerate growth, test new product launches, and gain a larger market share, especially if they are a premium brand.”

This behavioural shift is also redefining category economics. “Growth is becoming frequency-led rather than basket-led, driven by repeat purchases, time-of-day demand spikes and context-specific consumption. As a result, channel-specific strategies are emerging as critical levers for success,” he added.

‘Products seized in Haryana are counterfeit Mounjaro’

Our Bureau
Mumbai

American healthcare major Eli Lilly and Company has confirmed that the products recently seized by the Haryana drug control authority were counterfeit, falsely bearing the brand name of its global weightloss drug — Mounjaro (tirzepatide).

About 10 days ago, the State regulatory authority said it had seized fake Mounjaro in Gurugram.

“These seized counterfeit products were not manufactured by Lilly and did not originate from Lilly's authorised and verified supply chain,” a note from Eli Lilly and Company (India) said.

Most of the counterfeit products identified had been recovered by the authorities, the company said, urging

people to buy the product only from authorised distributors and licensed pharmacies, and on a valid prescription.

“In line with directions issued by the authority, the supply of genuine Lilly product through authorised distributors and licensed pharmacies continues without interruption,” the company said.

PATIENT SAFETY

Winslow Tucker, President and General Manager, Eli Lilly and Company (India), said, “Counterfeit products are not manufactured under approved quality controls and may pose significant risks to patient safety and public health. We will continue to take steps to protect patients from the risks of counterfeit and other unsafe products worldwide, includ-



SIGNIFICANT RISK. The seized counterfeit products were not manufactured by Lilly and did not originate from its authorised and verified supply chain, said the company

ing working with regulators and law enforcement.”

Lilly said that its patented tirzepatide molecule is marketed in India under two brand names — Mounjaro and Yurpeak (sold by Cipla).

Mounjaro has been pegging over ₹100 crore sales in India over the last several months, leading the estim-

isk's semaglutide — the active ingredient in its weightloss and diabetes drugs Wegovy and Ozempic, respectively — went off patent.

STAY VIGILANT

Lilly pointed out that counterfeit products may look “very similar” to genuine products, urging patients, caregivers and healthcare professionals to remain vigilant. “Suspected counterfeit medicines may include products obtained from unauthorised or unlicensed sources; packaging that appears tampered with or damaged, missing batch number, expiry date or manufacturer details; packaging that looks inconsistent with approved product packaging, including misspellings, unfamiliar logos, or different labels,” it added.

